

Ian Ranasinghe

LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/in/ianranasinghe](https://www.linkedin.com/in/ianranasinghe)

Location: Manchester, UK

Role: Product Designer / Full Stack Developer

Skills: Figma, React, Flutter, JavaScript, HTML & CSS.

UX/Product Designer & Builder with 5+ years experience delivering SaaS and government-backed platforms.

My non-traditional career path gives me a unique perspective on design and software. I've worked across industries, understanding tools and the people and workflows behind them in every form: software, hardware, and physical systems.

My portfolio includes government-backed projects like **Talk English** (led by Manchester City Council and supported by the Department for Communities and Local Government) and **Northcoders Learn to Code**, a platform I designed as both the first touchpoint for new students and a core system for delivering the bootcamp curriculum.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Stack

Founder, Product Designer & Developer

Nov 2024 – Present

Stack is a modern notes app. Your own scroll feed space to write notes, save media, and organise it all however you want.

It is also the place to arrange the material behind an idea (images, audio, clips, references, research, and words) and turn it into structured context and instructions for a computer to act on.

Stack moves us beyond the chat interface. In a space where text becomes simple to organise, Agency is manifestable.

- Designed and built Stack end to end in Flutter for iOS, Android and web: a personal organisation OS (stacks, branches, labels, threads) where curated context becomes action through chat and a dedicated Agent desk.
- Invented the Agent desk model so a hosted agency can file plans, research, shopping and coding work into a write-safe workspace with attention labels, without rewriting the user's own organisation.
- Built a general-agent runtime on private GCP VMs running OpenClaw and Chromium (no public IP, VPC isolation, on-demand wake), with browse evidence gates so "Done" requires real tool results, not model narration.
- Designed Ultra as diversity-before-compression: independent planning harnesses across frontier models, provenance-aware merge into one execution contract, and protected tests the builder cannot weaken (pre-launch / waitlist).
- Designed agent commerce for trust: structured browse vs buy, options on the desk not a chat wall, Agent Pay with merchant-confirmed paid only, and payment credentials kept out of the model path.
- Own interaction design and systems engineering as a solo founder, including custom navigation (rotating HomeButton, drag-to-chat, swipe-select), a full design system with GPU shaders, billing, guest isolation and security boundaries between app and agent planes.

- [Stack](#)

Northcoders

Lead Product Designer & Full Stack Software Engineer

Nov 2019 – Nov 2024

- **Northcoders Learn To Code Platform**

- Designed from inception, creating a scalable design system that supports nationwide bootcamp delivery.
- Built UX/UI for student onboarding, assessment, interactive learning modules, and ga mentor/admin dashboards—core to delivering all bootcamp content.
- [Northcoders L2C](#)

Led end-to-end design for external client products:

- **Talk English**

- Designed learner and teacher interfaces for a government-backed language-learning app adopted by multiple councils (Manchester, Bradford, Wakefield).
- Focused on accessibility for adults with little or no English—using visual-first navigation, large tap targets, and offline support—while enabling tutor integration.
- Helped Northcoders secure the contract through design-led pitch, delivering a product that supports thousands of learners in building real-world language confidence.
- [Video Overview](#) | [Talk English](#)

- **Sparedesk**

- Designed and delivered branding (including logo), UX, and UI for a flexible workspace marketplace connecting businesses and remote workers across the UK.
- Collaborated with the founder to shape product vision, then translated requirements into a streamlined booking experience for listing and reserving desks, private offices, and meeting rooms.
- Worked hands-on with engineers to ensure design fidelity through to production.
- [sparedesk.io](#)

- **MST Systems**

- Designed and delivered UX and UI for MST Systems, a strength training app created by elite coach Shane Jerman and trusted by world-class athletes, including Mark Felix and Lucy Underdown.
- Developed flows for customizable programming, video-based learning, and progress tracking—supporting users from beginners to World's Strongest Man competitors.
- Partnered with the founder to translate his vision into a scalable digital product, then worked closely with engineers to ensure implementation.
- [App Store](#) | [Video](#)

- **Internal Learner Management System**

- Led UX design for core internal platform used by tutors and operations teams to manage student progression and maintain compliance with Ofsted standards.
- Collaborated directly with educators to design workflows for attendance tracking, grading, and learner support, improving efficiency and data accuracy.

- **Northcoders Jobs Board**

- Designed and developed a jobs board to connect graduates with hiring partners, streamlining application and tracking processes.

- Delivered responsive UI and intuitive navigation to enhance usability for both employers and students.

- **The Idol – Dorris**

- Designed and co-developed a reusable chatbot builder for The Idol, the fintech platform powering major brands such as GoCompare, Compare the Market, and Legal & General.
- Transformed an initial brief for a simple chatbot into a full visual CMS canvas for building and managing conversational flows, integrated with Dialogflow for Natural Language Processing.
- Enabled non-technical editors to create, test, and deploy white-labeled chatbots without developer support, significantly reducing build time and scaling across multiple insurance products.
- Initially hired as a Junior Engineer but pivoted to lead product design responsibilities due to team needs.
- [Dev Incubator demo video](#)

Sky

Customer Advisor, later Active Management Team

Jun 2017 – Jul 2019

- Delivered front-line support for TV and broadband customers, ensuring high service quality.
- Participated in product feedback and user testing sessions for Sky Q and network products, gaining insight into large-scale UX processes.
- Identified pain points in customer service workflows and designed prototype solutions to reduce callbacks, submitting improvements to internal tool design.
- Learned best practices in enterprise tool UX, contrasting with previous experience of fragmented legacy systems (so much better than the co-op).

BuyAssociation

Digital Marketing Executive

Sep 2016 – Dec 2016

- Designed and coded marketing emails, managed CRM data, and optimized campaign performance.
- Created digital ads and website banners, applying brand consistency and visual design principles.
- First introduced to a/b testing and configuring pixels to generate sales
- Secured the role after creating a spec campaign for Aldi pitched to McCann, which led to a referral from a managing partner to BuyAssociation's leadership.
 - [Aldi Ad](#)

The Co-operative Bank

Customer Advisor

Jun 2016 – Sep 2016

- Delivered front-line support for personal banking customers while navigating complex internal systems.
- Worked in the blue pyramid
- Gained first-hand insight into enterprise software UX—observing fragmented, legacy tools and their impact on employee workflows.
- Observed large-scale brand and internal communication design across multiple sectors (banking, retail, and member services), gaining insight into how design operates at scale in a complex organization.
- Got to see the belly of a giant started by 28 working class folk

United Business Media

Recruitment Media Account Executive

Jan 2014 – Nov 2014

- Managed recruitment ad campaigns for clients across print and digital platforms, including leading design publications such as Building Design and Building.co.uk.
- Created visuals and layouts for job ads, building early expertise in design principles and brand alignment. (much more fun than cold calling to sell ad space to recruiters)
- Learned CMS workflows and digital publishing processes while collaborating with editorial and sales teams.
- Updated and managed website content, including ad placements, featured spots, and banner campaigns.
- Gained strong grounding in sales, client relations, and content strategy in a competitive B2B media environment.

Stellas Kitchen

Co-Founder

Oct 2012 – Nov 2013

- Learned how different it feels to sell something you've made.
- Co-designed and helped build the kitchen layout for operational efficiency in a small space.
- Operated a family-run Sri Lankan food business in a converted shipping container at Chester Lakes.
- Created the brand identity, including logo and menu design.
- Helped design the menu working with Mum whose cooking is superb.

Deva Heating and Plumbing

Labourer

Jan 2011 – Nov 2013

- Assisted with installations and repairs on domestic plumbing and heating projects.
- Worked on the house of a producer for Blue Planet, learned so much about design from her, her new house and everything in it was beautiful and told a story and I got to watch her restore it, her and the painters showed me a bar for art.
- Developed efficiency and prioritization skills working under a mentor managing multiple urgent client demands.

Lessgo Ltd

Founder (Non-technical)

Oct 2010 – Jun 2013

- Founded and led development of an early-stage travel platform targeting the 18–30 market, defining product vision and brand strategy.
- Built partnerships with major festivals including T in the Park and V Fest to drive early traction.
- Designed initial branding and UX prototypes; recruited a front-end developer to improve design execution.
- Managed budgeting and engaged consultancies for project scoping, gaining hands-on experience in cost modeling and vendor management.
- Learned critical lessons in fundraising and runway management after failing to secure capital—insights that shaped my approach to future product development.
- [Lessgo Ltd](#)

Mitchells & Butlers

Various Roles (Kitchen Porter, Waiter, Barman)

May 2010 – Jun 2013

- Delivered service across multiple roles, gaining deep understanding of customer experience and operational workflows.
- Learned how design in environment, layout, and presentation impacts user satisfaction and business performance.
- Observed large-scale brand revamp, developing insight into change management and standards implementation.
- Learned the art of culture in the workplace here.

Hugo Boss (Tessuti Group)

Sales Assistant

Dec 2007 – Aug 2010

- Gained first hand experience watching the owners family and my manager work closely to grow the business online.
- Observed high-level business strategy during expansion and acquisition (eventually sold to JD Sports).
- Delivered premium customer experiences and drove sales through expert client engagement and brand presentation.
- Supported new store launches, including event coordination, franchise compliance, and local business partnerships.
- I was like my managers Padawan (my manager being a master in service, good sales and fun at work).

Grosvenor Pulford Hotel and Spa

Waiter/Barman

May 2007 – Dec 2007

- Delivered high-end service at a luxury venue, sharpening communication and client management under pressure.
- Gained early insight into operational design by observing owners structure workflows and share friendship with staff for efficiency.
- Learned resilience and adaptability in high-stress kitchen environments, shaping a systems-thinking approach to problem-solving.

WHSmith

Sales Assistant

Sep 2006 – May 2007

- Built strong customer service foundations
- Learned how product presentation and diversification impacts sales.
- Handled retail duties including till operation and customer service.
- First experiences of groups of strangers coming together to work.

Robert Allsop (Private Estate)

Labourer

Jun 2005 – Jun 2011

- Learned to stay patient when solving messy problems.

- Learned the true importance of keeping workspaces tidy and functional.
- Saw how good design in a garage or smallholding makes life easier—everything had its place.
- As he got older, helped him deal with Parkinson's—lifting, supporting, he had a few falls where I was the first to find him.
- Helped with all sorts: cutting grass, walking dogs, cleaning cars, chopping logs and odd jobs around the estate.
- Assisted in his construction projects, joinery, and mechanical repairs.

Richard Vaughan Davies of Vaughan Davies (Mold Property)

Labourer

Jan 2004 – Oct 2004

- Helped my dad construct a wooden bridge from the owners house over the River Alyn to his car park.
- Learned the difference between using tools and using tools properly.
- Discovered the importance of well designed tools (like chain blocks!).

Chester Standard / Chronicle

Newspaper Delivery

Jun 2003 – Sep 2005

- Delivered newspapers.
- Sorted leaflets into newspapers.

Pierce Farms

Milk Delivery Assistant

Nov 2002 – Jun 2003

- 4am Starts.
- The owner Mrs Pierce always made time to speak to customers & ensured sweet coffee and buttery toast before each shift.

EDUCATION

Northcoders

Full Stack Software Development (JavaScript)

Jul 2019 – Oct 2020

West Cheshire College

Level 3 – Web Page Design

Jan 2010 – Mar 2010

Level 3 BTEC National Diploma – Business Studies

Sep 2007 – Jun 2009

Chartered Institute of Environmental Health

Level 2 – Food Safety in Catering

Sep 2007 – Aug 2008

Coleg Cambria (Yale College)

Level 3 BTEC National Diploma – Business Studies

Sep 2006 – May 2007

Bishop's Bluecoat C of E High School

Level 3 – Business Studies

Sep 2005 – Jun 2006

PORTFOLIO HIGHLIGHTS

- [Stack](#)
- [Northcoders Learn to Code Platform](#)
- [Talk English Platform – Video Overview](#)
- [Talk English](#)
- [Sparedesk Marketplace](#)
- [MST Systems App – App Store](#)
- [MST Systems App – Demo Video](#)
- [Chatbot Builder for The Idol – Dev incubator Demo](#)
- [Aldi Spec Ad](#)